

franchise installment, Baldur's Gate III. But then it was abruptly cancelled in 2003, wut? The team was shocked, "why would you cancel Baldur's Gate III?!" But they immediately shifted all of their attention to another project, a backup project if you will, called "Van Buren". This was of course, the code-name for Fallout 3. And Black Isle was more than happy to be working on wasteland again.

Van Buren's story seemed solid. Prisoner making his escape under attack, hounded by an unknown assailant, you roam around Utah and Colorado looking for answers while choosing to make or break a fading Brotherhood of Steel. Tough choices were aplenty as was the norm, and they were bringing in quick travel as well, although you'd have to work for it. Everything seemed right, and it looked like we would be getting a stellar game. But thanks to the financial status of Interplay because of poor returns in recent years (they were \$59 million in debt) and poor management by Titus, it came as no surprise that Fallout 3 was shelved, with most of the work on it already done. Urquhart resigned, took the project leads with him, and went on to found Obsidian Entertainment.

The guys at Titus believed PC gaming was dying (pfft yea, right) and the future was in consoles. So they were like "why waste resources on slow-paced pc games?" So they dissolved Black Isle, laid off whatever little of the employees remained and dished out

Fallout: Brotherhood of Steel in 2004. It released only for the Xbox and PS2. Titus Interactive collapsed soon after Brotherhood of Steel landed. No surprise there. While they called it an "Action-RPG" there was nothing RPG about it. Linear gameplay, some platforming here and there, shooting and hacking, and a little bit of puzzle solving. That's it. Makes Fallout Tactics look more appealing.

Now Interplay was in a tight spot. At this point nobody even knew if they existed. Then suddenly out of the blue, in November 2006 they decide "we wanna make a Fallout MMO." Well okay then, but where are you going to get the money for that? The estimated start-up price for a Fallout MMO was a staggering \$75 million. And they were still \$11 million in debt. This is where Bethesda Softworks stepped in and paid off a little over half of their debt. Bethesda were the established kings of the RPG genre at the time with The Elder Scrolls: Morrowind release of 2002. And it turns out a lot of the folks at Bethesda were big Fallout fans. In

2007 Bethesda outright bought the Fallout IP for another \$5.75 million. Interplay were given 2 more years to finish the Fallout MMO they were working on.

And we're finally at Fallout 3

When Bethesda started working on Fallout, they didn't touch Van Buren. In fact, when a playable demo made it onto the Internet they didn't even mind. What they wanted was to resurrect the Fallout they knew and loved. Bethesda wouldn't repeat past mis-

